

Prof. Sandra Sieber  
Prof.email: [ssieber@iese.edu](mailto:ssieber@iese.edu)  
Office: B401  
Phone: 504175  
Assistant email: [mortega@iese.edu](mailto:mortega@iese.edu)  
Prof. Desirée Pacheco  
Prof.email: [dpacheco@iese.edu](mailto:dpacheco@iese.edu)  
Office: B407  
Phone: 506454  
Assistant email: [dclerc@iese.edu](mailto:dclerc@iese.edu)

## Corporate Entrepreneurship (CORPENT)

### Introduction

As firms face increasing pressure from technological disruption, market volatility, and geopolitical instability, the ability to innovate from within becomes critical. The Corporate Entrepreneurship (CORPENT) course is designed to prepare MBA students to understand and lead innovation initiatives within established organizations. Drawing on real-world case studies and field-based insights, the course examines both internal and external approaches to innovation—ranging from intrapreneurial project launches to strategic startup partnerships and corporate venture capital.

Students will explore how firms manage the paradox of ambidexterity—simultaneously running existing businesses efficiently while exploring transformative new opportunities. We focus on the specific challenges of strategic alignment, resource allocation, organizational design, and cultural transformation that corporate entrepreneurs face. The course further addresses how emerging technologies, particularly GenAI, are reshaping innovation systems and requiring new governance structures.

CORPENT uses a blended pedagogical approach, with each double session comprising a case discussion, a guest speaker session with experienced practitioners, and a faculty-led conceptual wrap-up. In select sessions, workshops and field visits replace speakers to provide immersive learning experiences.

Prof. Sandra Sieber leads the overall design and integration of the course, ensuring that students connect individual tools and concepts to broader corporate transformation challenges. She introduces foundational frameworks around ambidexterity, GenAI adoption, and innovation governance. Prof. Desirée Pacheco contributes deep expertise on open innovation, corporate-startup collaboration, and ecosystem strategy. Her sessions focus on mechanisms like intrapreneurship labs, corporate venture capital, and the venture client model, building on her extensive academic research and field collaborations.

### Objectives

Understand how large firms structure for innovation and manage the tension between exploitation and exploration.

- Learn to evaluate and apply mechanisms for internal innovation and external collaboration.
- Build skills in innovation governance, venture design, and corporate-startup partnerships.

## Content

- Ambidexterity and dual transformation
- Intrapreneurship models (Kickbox, Labs, Innovation Units)
- Corporate Venture Capital and governance
- Open Innovation ecosystems
- Metrics for innovation performance
- GenAI strategy and integration

## Evaluation

- SE1 (Individual Written Assignment): 20%
- SE3 (Group Project + Final Presentation): 30%
- SE4 (Class Participation): 50%

Group Project Deliverables: - Session 7: 1-page firm summary & innovation challenge

- Session 14: Draft strategy & peer feedback
- Sessions 19–20: Final presentation + executive summary

## Course Outline & Bibliography

### TITLE OF SESSION & MATERIAL

|     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1-2 | <i>Dual Transformation</i><br><u>Case</u>   Hallmark Cards, Inc.: In Search of Turnaround (W29725) + Pisano HBR The Hard Truth About Innovative Cultures (R1901C)<br><u>Interactive Lecture</u> : What is Corporate Entrepreneurship, and why now                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 3-4 | <i>Org. Challenges in Innovation</i><br><u>Case</u> : The Challenges of Corporate Innovation (E-213-E)<br><u>Interactive session</u> : Invited Guest Speaker                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 5   | <i>Incubating Innovation within the Corporation</i><br><u>Case</u> : “Kickboxing” at Adobe Systems, SCG-510<br>Preparation Questions: <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Should Adobe work to expand the reach to the Kickbox program? What are the benefits and potential risks of doing so?</li><li>• Should Adobe change the way in which it supports and sustains the concepts identified by the Kickbox program?</li><li>• How would you assess Adobe’s goals and ambitions for the Kickbox program overall?</li></ul> |

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| 6     | <p><i>Working with Startups: Corporate Accelerators</i></p> <p><u>Case:</u> Intrapreneurship in Telefónica: Wayra, a Company Faster Than the Wind, E-162-E</p> <p>Preparation Questions:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Identify key success factors in the launching of Wayra.</li> <li>• What are your thoughts about the way in which Wayra was launched?</li> <li>• Why or why not should Telefónica launch and grow Wayra?</li> <li>• How do you see Wayra's role in Telefónica moving forward?</li> <li>• Shall Wayra open more Academies? Where? Shall it pay more attention to the selection process? Shall Wayra give more services to the startups in the academy? Please, be specific.</li> </ul> <p>Optional Reading: Open Innovation, IESE Business School, 2023</p> <p><a href="https://media.iese.edu/research/pdfs/76587.pdf">https://media.iese.edu/research/pdfs/76587.pdf</a></p> |
| 7-8   | <p><i>Incubating Innovation within the Organization</i>   The Value of Hackathons  </p> <p><u>AI WorkHack Hackathon</u></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 9-10  | <p><i>Innovation Metrics</i>   Innovation Accounting &amp; KPI Mapping</p> <p><u>Workshop:</u> Build your KPI Map</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 11-12 | <p><i>Working with Startups: Corporate Venture Capital</i></p> <p><u>Case:</u> TDK Ventures: Aligning Corporate Strategy with Venture Innovation, E-249-E</p> <p>Preparation Questions:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What is the Corporate Venture Capital (CVC) model? What advantages do you see?</li> <li>• What has made TDK Ventures successful? How does it compare to other CVCs?</li> <li>• What challenges does TDK Ventures face? How should they address them?</li> </ul> <p><u>Guest Speaker.</u> To be announced</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 13-14 | <p><i>Innovation Capability Mapping</i></p> <p><u>Workshop + Field Visit</u>   Barcelona Supercomputing Center</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

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| 15-16 | <p><i>Working with Startups: The Venture Client Model</i></p> <p><u>Case:</u> How Corporates Co-innovate with Startups: The BMW Startup Garage, Insead, IN1626</p> <p>Preparation questions:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What changes in your industry are driven by startup innovation? How have startups impacted your company directly? How has your company dealt with it?</li> <li>• How does the Venture Client (VCL) model compare to other open innovation mechanisms used by BMW? What advantages does it have? What are the drawbacks?</li> </ul> |
| 17-18 | <p><i>Ambidexterity in Practice</i></p> <p><u>Case:</u> Two pulses, one heart: the Vitalis transformation challenge - Preparation sheet.</p> <p><u>Interactive Lecture:</u> Building an Entrepreneurial Mindset in Organizations</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 19-20 | <p><i>Integration &amp; Reflection</i></p> <p><u>Group Presentations</u>   Final strategy pitch + wrap-up</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |

## Bibliography

## Professor's Biography



Sandra Sieber is Professor in the Entrepreneurship Department. She served as the academic director of the IESE Global Executive MBA for 7 years. From 2012 to 2014 she was based at IESE Business School's New York Center, where she served as director of academic programs.

She joined IESE in 2000. Previously, she was Associate Professor at University Pompeu Fabra in Barcelona, Spain. From 2001 to 2004, she was appointed as the academic director of the PwC-IESE ebCenter. In 2003, she was a Visiting Scholar at the Sloan School of Management, MIT.

Currently, most of her work is centered on how the digital rise is affecting organizations from a variety of perspectives. First, she avidly studies how the current technological changes impact business models, both in terms of how they allow the rise of new value propositions, as well as for their potential to impact their target markets. In this vein, she is especially interested in understanding how existing companies can increase their capabilities to quickly adapt and react, and how their main leaders have to develop a digital mindset to be able to incorporate the digital dimensions into their daily decision making.

From an industry perspective, Professor Sieber is especially interested in those that are being transformed by recent technological advances, such as media and entertainment, telecommunications, banking, retail and automotive.

Professor Sieber has also worked extensively on the impact of information and communication technologies on organizational and individual work practices, being especially interested in the most recent developments on the impact of social and interactive media on organizations, in particular vis-à-vis inter- and intraorganizational collaboration.

Professor Sieber has extensive experience working with executive audiences in Europe, North and South America, Asia, Middle East and Africa. She has taught, directed custom programs, and consulted with multinational companies, including Oracle, BBVA, La Caixa, Banco Santander, Telefónica, Vodafone, Komatsu, Olympus, Boston Scientific and Desigual. She regularly advises early-stage start-ups, incubators and investment funds on issues of business model and technology design.



Desirée Pacheco is Professor in the Entrepreneurship Department. Prior to her doctoral studies, Professor Pacheco worked as a management and technology consultant with Accenture. During this experience she worked with a variety of companies in defining their strategic direction and implementing new processes and systems. In addition, Professor Pacheco has more than 10 years of experience teaching courses in the areas of entrepreneurship and strategic management, and her teaching combined active consulting with more than 50 startups and small businesses.

Her research interests relate to the interface between institutions, entrepreneurship and firm strategy. She applies these areas of research to the study of sustainable business. She is particularly interested in the strategies that entrepreneurs undertake to bring about institutional change, such as changes in policies, industry practices, and norms. She also studies the effect of social movement activism on emerging industries and the new ventures that operate within them and the ability of emerging industries to drive cultural shifts.

Professor Pacheco was granted the 2015 Emerging Scholar Award by the Organizations and the Natural Environment (ONE) division of the Academy of Management (the largest international association for management scholars). This award is granted to early career academics who have already made outstanding research contributions in the area of organizations and the natural environment, and who have a strong potential to continue making such contributions.

Her research has been published in the *Journal of Business Venturing*, *Journal of Management*, *Organization Science*, *Strategic Management Journal*, *The Academy of Management Journal*, and *The Academy of Management Review*, amongst other publications.

Professor Pacheco is an editorial board member of the *Journal of Management* and the *Journal of Business Venturing*.

## **Additional Information for Reporting and Accreditation purposes**

### **Learning Outcomes**

Apply ambidextrous thinking to corporate strategy and innovation design

- Diagnose organizational bottlenecks and recommend structural responses
- Analyze startup partnership models and propose governance solutions
- Evaluate GenAI's strategic integration and risks
- Construct feasible innovation strategies using real-world evidence

## **Sustainable Development Goals (SDG)**

For official reporting purposes, we are required to state below the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) discussed in this course. This list is not intended to serve as an illustration of how to approach sustainability issues. We acknowledge that there might be other relevant topics on sustainability not included in the SDGs that might also be addressed in class.

SDG 4 – Quality Education

SDG 5 – Gender Equality

SDG 8 – Decent Work and Economic Growth

SDG 9 – Industry Innovation and Infrastructure

SDG 17 – Partnerships for the Goals